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Social Identity and Language: Theoretical and Methodological Issues

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■ Social identity has been a focus of research in various disciplines, such as social psychology, linguistics, and second language acquisition (SLA). Although there are a number of similarities among researchers across disciplines in the study of social identity, several underlying differences prevail in approaches to theories and methodologies. The aim of this commentary is twofold: (a) to provide an overview of some of the most salient social identity research by discussing various theoretical stances and methodologies and (b) to critique the theories and methodologies employed in social identity research. We make suggestions for future research in the concluding section.

THEORETICAL ISSUES

Theoretical Stances

One of the most notable theories of social identity was developed by Tajfel (1974, 1981), a social psychologist who believed that identity is derived from group membership. Tajfel (1974) defines social identity as "that part of an individual's self-concept which derives from his knowledge of his membership of a social group (or groups) together with the

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emotional significance attached to that membership" (p. 69). Tajfel maintains that because individuals' identities are derived from in-group memberships, individuals may choose to change group membership if their present one does not adequately satisfy those elements of the social identity that they view positively. However, changing group membership, and thus social identity to a certain extent, may not always be possible, leaving individuals with limited options: changing their interpretations of the characteristics of their in-group so as to view them in a more positive light or engaging in social action to change the situation. However, Tajfel does not explain how this is to be done.

Drawing heavily on Tajfel's theory, Giles and Johnson (1981, 1987) developed their ethnolinguistic identity theory, focusing on language as a salient marker of group membership and social identity. Giles and Johnson also discuss group membership, hypothesizing that individuals compare their own social group to out-groups in order to make their own favorably distinct and that positive distinctiveness enables individuals to achieve a positive social identity. If the comparison is negative, however, the authors maintain that an individual may adopt several strategies to attain a more positive social identity. One is to assimilate into a group that the individual or the individual's group views more positively. If language is a salient marker of group membership, the individual may face linguistic adaptations that may result in subtractive bilingualism or even language erosion if a large number of members of a particular group assimilate into another to achieve a more positive group identity.

Interactional sociolinguists, such as Gumperz (1970, 1982) and Heller (1982, 1987, 1988), also focus on language in their research on social identity. They believe that "social identity and ethnicity are in large part established and maintained through language" (Gumperz & Cook-Gumperz, 1982, p. 7). They conducted research on specific speech events to examine the relationship between speakers' choices of linguistic categories such as phonology, morphology, syntax, and lexis and the social situation. They also looked for instances of code switching, either between languages or between varieties of the same language, to find out in what situation and with what interactants code switching occurs as "linguistic alternates within the repertoire serve to symbolize the differing social identities which members may assume" (Blom & Gumperz, 1972, p. 421). The minority group's language is often the in-group "we code" language, whereas the majority group's language is considered the out-group or "they code" language (Gumperz, 1982, p. 66), and code switching may signal various group memberships and identities. Gumperz (1970) argues that a microlevel analysis reveals that code switching serves "definite and clearly understandable communicative ends" (p. 9) and is meaningful when analyzed in terms of the conversational context.

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In their study of code switching in Hemnesberget, Norway, Blom and Gumperz (1972) found that most of the members of the community spoke two varieties of Norwegian, the local dialect, Ranamål, and one of the two national dialects, Bokmål. As the local dialect carried great prestige, and as "a person's native speech is regarded as an integral part of his family background, a sign of his local identity" (p. 411), residents of Hemnesberget used that dialect in their interactions with other residents in order to mark their in-group identity. However, when interacting with members of other communities and with tourists, the residents would use the standard dialect "at least until the participants' identity would become more clearly known" (p. 424). Additionally, speakers switched codes depending on whom they interacted with within the community, and thus usage was not always consistent. Students switched to the standard dialect while discussing academic issues even though they were all Hemnesberget natives and spoke the local dialect. As education was carried out in the standard dialect, the students may have felt they had to switch to it in order to mark their identity as students.

Heller (1982, 1987, 1988) also believes that language and ethnicity interact in several ways. Specifically, ethnicity may limit an individual's ability to participate in some social situations and networks and may signal a shared ethnic background, which is reinforced by a sharing of behavior, values, language, and lifestyles. Language may "symbolize group identity and become emblems of that identity, especially when there is contact with other groups whose ways of being are different" (1982, p. 3). This view is similar to Gumperz's notion of a *we code* and a *they code* to signal in-group and out-group membership and identity, respectively, and reflects Giles and Johnson's (1981, 1987) ethnolinguistic identity theory, in which language is a salient marker of group membership and identity. However, rather than focusing on choices between groups in terms of identification due to positive and negative associations with in-group and out-group membership, as Giles and Johnson do, Heller (1982) focuses on language choice and actual language use in specific contexts. She defines *language choice* as the choice of language code and *language use* as the "manipulation of conventionally-defined ways of saying things" (p. 4) within the chosen code. These choices serve to "indicate social relationships based on shared or unshared group memberships" (p. 5) and thus help construct social identity in specific contexts.

In an early study, Heller (1982) focused on language choice in interactions in private enterprises in Quebec, in this case in a brewery, to discover how language was being used among workers from different ethnic backgrounds. She concludes that "language is a symbol of ethnic identity, and language choice is a symbol of ethnic relations as well as a

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means of communication" (p. 308). Furthermore, class divisions in each of the ethnolinguistic communities created differences in language use within each language variety, and these differences carried social and stylistic significance in certain situations. In a later study, Heller (1992), along with Lévy, studied linguistically mixed marriages in Canada, focusing on Francophone women in order to examine the value of French and English in enabling the women to gain access to resources valued economically and socially. The researchers found that the women lived with contradictions in their daily life, such as bringing up their children bilingually even though the women were part of the dominated linguistic minority and sometimes experienced negative feelings toward Anglophones. These negative feelings were also in conflict with the fact that the women were married to Anglophones. The researchers state that these contradictions were the manifestations of life on a linguistic boundary, to which the women both belong and contribute, and view social identity as contradictory and contextually bound rather than dichotomous.

Recently, social identity has also been a focus of research by SLA theorists (Goldstein, 1995; Peirce, 1993, 1995; Siegal, 1995), driven in part by the failure of SLA theorists to develop a theory of social identity that adequately addresses the language learner and the context of language learning (Peirce, 1995). Peirce argues that SLA theorists have not adequately explored "how inequitable relations of power limit the opportunities L2 learners have to practice the target language outside the classroom" (p. 12). Drawing from data she collected in her longitudinal case study of the language learning experiences of immigrant women in Canada, Peirce has constructed a theory of social identity, stating that "power relations play a crucial role in social interactions between language learners and target language speakers" (p. 3). Peirce, building on work by Heller (1987), also states that it is through language that learners gain or are denied access to social networks wherein opportunities for speaking are created and that language is the medium through which learners develop and negotiate their identity. Thus, social structures play an important role in enabling a learner to use the target language and therefore should be incorporated into a theory of SLA, which Peirce has sought to do. Peirce's pioneering theory of social identity in SLA builds on Heller's (1987) conceptualization of language and ethnicity, and it shifts SLA research in a new and much-needed theoretical direction.

In a study of language choice among female Portuguese immigrant workers in a Canadian factory, Goldstein (1995) also found that power structures influenced the women's acquisition and use of English. Goldstein found that Portuguese, rather than English, was associated with social and economic benefits, as many of the Portuguese women

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who worked in the factory had few opportunities to learn English and relied on Portuguese network ties to find jobs. Once working in the factory, the women used Portuguese to develop social ties with the other Portuguese workers and establish a sense of solidarity or "sisterhood." This helped the women economically, for the women often helped their "sisters" on the assembly line, ensuring that they all kept up their work load and their jobs. As the women had no hope of advancement in the factory, the use of English was not valued but rather associated with social and economic risk, as it alienated them from their sisters. Furthermore, because of family obligations and low social and economic status in Canada, the women did not have access to evening ESL classes that would allow them to further their education. Goldstein concludes by advocating a critical pedagogy of ESL that recognizes that learners may have differential access to power and resources and that aims at helping learners challenge their community and societal status and gain greater access to resources as well as social and economic power.

Theoretical Concerns

Although the theories discussed above have made significant contributions to the understanding of social identity and its relationship to language, we do have several concerns about them. Tajfel (1974, 1981), for example, maintains that social identity is dynamic but does not discuss multiple group memberships. Most individuals belong to several groups based not only on ethnic and gender characteristics but also on personal beliefs and economic circumstances. Individuals may also belong to several ethnic groups that could be defined by language. Rather than choosing to belong to one group or the other, as Tajfel's theory maintains, the individual may wish to identify with a certain group in specific contexts (i.e., speak different languages in different situations).

In their theory of ethnolinguistic identity, Giles and Johnson (1981, 1987) do not take into consideration certain characteristics that differ among groups and between individuals (i.e., ethnicity, language, appearance, and personality). Not only do ethnic groups differ in behavior, language, and manifestation of an identity, but individuals within each group also differ in each of these elements. Although Giles and Johnson's propositions attempt to take individual differences into account, their categories are too rigid and attempt to cast diverse people into narrow categories of ethnolinguistic identity.

This shortcoming leads to another concern about the prior research by Tajfel (1974, 1981) and Giles and Johnson (1981, 1987). Their theories of identity were formed on the basis of research on a few individuals who have been taken to represent the behavior of individuals in their respective groups. Social identity is individual, and developing a

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hypothesis of social identity that categorizes an individual's behavior into groups, and the groups into determined categories, denies the individual and dynamic nature of social identity.

Problems also exist in interactional sociolinguistic theories. It is still not clear what kinds of social conditions facilitate the development and use of code switching as a communicative and social strategy. And little is known about the extent to which different types of code switching are related to different types of boundary maintenance or change processes or whether the presence or absence of code switching indicates certain configurations of intergroup and intragroup relations. Although the contribution of interactional sociolinguists to the study of social identity is undeniable, as language is a strong ethnic marker and the manifestation of a specific culture, one might wonder whether language as the only focus of study will narrow the scope of research on social identity and thus weaken the overall perspectives of multiple factors interacting to form one's social identity.

In the field of SLA, Peirce's (1995) social identity theory, which places great emphasis on the social context outside the language classroom for language learners to invest in, sounds promising. She argues that the notion of investment "attempts to capture the relationship of the language learner to the social world" and conceives of the language learner as having "a complex social identity and multiple desires" (pp. 17–18). However, the extent to which language teachers can empower students in such an investment needs more research.

METHODOLOGICAL CHOICES

Although many social identity researchers consider social identity to be dynamic, the very methods some have employed—questionnaires, observations, interviews, and so forth—do not allow for dynamism, as they are typically onetime occurrences. Except for a few structured interviews (Moghaddam & Perreault, 1992; Papademetre, 1994), most of the studies conducted by these social psychologists were confined to questionnaires and surveys. For example, to test their ethnolinguistic identity theory, Giles and Johnson (1987) distributed a five-section questionnaire to 34 Welsh bilingual adolescents. Wong-Rieger and Taylor (1981) used a five-part questionnaire to address the fundamental paradox of how an individual achieves a unitary self-identity despite membership in many different groups. Ogbu and Simons (1994) conducted a large-scale student survey to quantitatively test Ogbu's theory on cultural models of school achievement. Sachdev, Bourhis, Phang, and D'Eye (1988) conducted a survey via the Subjective Vitality Questionnaire and a sociolinguistic questionnaire among 31 Chinese Canadians to examine

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intergenerational effects amongst Chinese Canadian communities. Duran, Enright, and Rock (1985) conducted a questionnaire survey of the language characteristics of over 700 self-identified Hispanic freshmen entering 4-year colleges in the 1982–1983 academic year. Lee (1993) conducted a survey among African American (n = 41) and Chinese American (n = 34) students to test his hypothesis that social identity (ethnic category) and salient intergroup comparisons would produce greater preference and perceived homogeneity within the in-group than within the out-group.

In contrast, interactional sociolinguists such as Gumperz (1970, 1982) and Heller (1982, 1987, 1988) have conducted a number of longitudinal studies on both speech communities and individuals within those communities in order to study social identity and language. Heller conducted her research by using observation, conversation analysis, and interviews in various Anglophone and Francophone communities. Heller and Lévy (1992) interviewed 28 Francophone women married to Anglophones and living in three different cities in Ontario.

In the field of SLA, researchers (Goldstein, 1995; Peirce, 1993, 1995; Siegal, 1995) also used interviews, observations, and case studies in their work on language and social identity. Peirce (1995) employed in-depth interviews in her longitudinal study of five immigrant women in Canada, and Goldstein (1995) interviewed and observed Portuguese line workers in both English and Portuguese with the help of a research assistant who was fluent in both languages. Siegal (1995) conducted in-depth interviews with four women in her study of White women learning Japanese in Japan.

As seen, social identity has been studied across the various disciplines with various methodologies, such as questionnaires, surveys, interviews, observations, and case studies. Social psychologists have relied heavily on both questionnaires and surveys whereas interactional sociolinguists and L2 researchers have employed more dynamic research methodologies, such as interviews, observations, and case studies. We believe that, because social identity is a dynamic phenomenon, it should be studied with a methodology that is dynamic both in philosophy and in practice. No matter how detailed and carefully undertaken, onetime research cannot be adequate to study social identity, as social identity is often context bound, and therefore onetime research yields only one view of a complex phenomenon. As ethnographer Moerman (1993) points out, researchers and journalists are often confounded "when they assume that a person who sometimes calls him- or herself by an ethnic label—on a questionnaire perhaps, or during an interview or at a ceremony—thereby always identifies with all others who use the same label for themselves. This habit of the trade misleads us" (p. 95). In other words,

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social identity is context dependent, so the data gathered through onetime research are problematic. Instead, the research should acknowledge and study the complex and contradictory nature of social identity.

DIRECTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

Where do we as researchers go from here? We think the complexity of social identity should be explored on a dynamic continuum that allows factors such as language, ethnicity, appearance, and personality to interplay in a complex fashion without beginnings and ends. To do this, we should do more longitudinal studies with appropriate methodological choices on language and social identity in order to understand different phases and multiple layers of social identity. We should also try to triangulate our data collection methods in order to get a better picture of the complex phenomenon. In addition, we need to question our own changing perspectives on social identities over an extended period of time and compare them with those of others from similar and different sociocultural backgrounds. We believe that studying our own histories can help us better understand the histories of others. In sum, language and social identity is an important issue, a holistic and dynamic understanding of which will help to shape the future direction of SLA research.

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